

Terramation

Gently transforming a person into soil: what the process is, how long it takes, what comes back to you, and what it costs.

What comes back is soil

Terramation gently transforms a person into soil, not ashes. Washington calls it natural organic reduction; the news calls it human composting. Only straw, alfalfa and sawdust go into the vessel, with the oxygen that flows through it. No chemicals, nothing added to change the body. What comes back is clean, fertile soil, ready to be planted in, scattered, or placed at the cemetery.

We provide terramation through Return Home, a licensed funeral home and terramation facility in Auburn and a preferred partner of Bonney Watson. You make the arrangements with us; the transformation takes place at their facility. Their staff and ours have done this together many times.

How the Process Works

About two months, in two halves



The vessel, laid with straw, greenery and flowers. This is the same vessel the person stays in.

We bring your loved one into our care and bathe and dress them here in a compostable garment, then take them to Return Home. They are laid in a sealed, environmentally controlled vessel on a bed of straw, alfalfa and sawdust, and that is when a laying-in ceremony happens. Oxygen flows through the vessel for **about 30 days** while the body's own microbes do the work. The material is then screened to take out anything not organic, and the screened soil rests and cools for **about another 30 days**. Expect about two months; we keep you posted rather than promising a date, because the process is allowed to finish rather than run on a clock.

Is the soil safe to handle and to plant in? Washington regulates this rather than leaving it to the provider. Before soil can be released it must pass pathogen testing and contain less than 0.01 mg per kilogram dry weight of physical contaminants, a category that includes intact bone, dental fillings and medical implants. It comes back as clean, fertile soil, and families plant in it.

The Laying-In Ceremony

The goodbye, at the vessel

A laying-in ceremony is the terramation equivalent of a viewing. Your loved one lies in their vessel, on the bed of organics, and the family gathers around to say goodbye, **in person, virtually, or both**, with a live webcast and a video tribute. **You decide what goes in and on the vessel**: anything organic, so flowers, food, letters. Children often take an active part, and placing a flower gives a child something to do at a moment when there is otherwise nothing. Anyone may lead it, clergy of any faith or a family member. **The vessel is the real one**, not a facade, and it is where your loved one stays. You can visit during the first 30 days.

The ceremony is priced separately and is optional. Families who do not hold one still say goodbye with us in the ways they would for any other arrangement.

Where the Soil May Go

What the law allows, and what we can offer at the cemetery

There is more of it than most families expect: a full return is roughly a cubic yard, about 250 pounds, in 10 to 15 burlap bags. You may take all of it, some, or none, and anything you do not take is scattered at Return Home's protected greenbelt near Auburn, which is not open for visits. Permission is the rule for the rest: your own garden is yours to plant, and anywhere else, ask first.

Terramated remains can be placed at Washington Memorial Park, in a standard-size plot. That gives your family a permanent, cared-for place with a name on it that anyone can visit, which is the one thing scattering on private land cannot give back later. Ask me and I will set aside the time to walk you through it.

What It Costs

Two charges, from our General Price List

Terramation

Natural Organic Reduction, from the General Price List, Alternative Methods of Disposition

Includes our basic services and staff, transfer into our care, bathing, the terramation itself, and use of a utility vehicle. It does not include staff or facilities for a visitation or ceremony.

Laying in Ceremony

Additional option, described above

A video tribute, a live webcast, and two hours of Return Home's facility and staff for the ceremony and in-person goodbye.

What these two do not cover. Cemetery property, placement at the park, a marker, certified death certificates and shipping of the soil are all priced separately. Ask me for a written quote covering everything you are actually considering.

Both figures are taken verbatim from the Bonney Watson General Price List effective April 2026. Prices are subject to change without notice. Ask me for the complete price list.

GENERALLY

\$895–\$7,795

Where a particular one falls in that range depends on the size, the location and the options you choose. I would rather give you a real number than a guess. Call or email me and I will put an exact quote in writing for you, with no obligation.

Come and talk it through

Terramation is still new to most families, and there is no wrong question about it. I can walk you through what happens, what it costs alongside everything else, and whether placing the soil at Washington Memorial Park is right for you. There is no cost to ask and no obligation.

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